



HIRING INSIGHTS • GERMANY

GERMANY WERKSTUDENT STARTER GUIDE

2026 EDITION • FOR ENGINEERING & TECH STUDENTS

Practical, recruiter-ready guidance on Werkstudent (working student) roles in Germany — what they are, how to find them, how to apply, and how to convert them into internships, thesis projects and full-time hiring.

How to use this guide

This guide is built for students who DM **WERKSTUDENT** and need something useful immediately: a clear explanation of the role, how to search, what to send, and how to present themselves professionally. It follows current official guidance from *Make it in Germany*, the federal portal for international workers and students.

Read it in one sitting (about 15 minutes), then use it as a reference. Pair it with the companion **Werkstudent Quick Checklist 2026** for a one-page action sheet.

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Best used as

A **first reply** to a student's DM about working-student roles, followed by a **role-specific** CV or portfolio resource. Do not send everything at once — one guide, one checklist, one CV sample is enough.

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01

What a Werkstudent role actually is

A **Werkstudent** (working student) role is part-time work for an enrolled university student, usually directly tied to the student's field of study. It is the most common bridge in Germany between coursework and full-time engineering employment.

Unlike a generic part-time job, a Werkstudent contract has a specific legal status: reduced social-insurance obligations, defined working-hour limits during lectures, and an expectation that the student stays enrolled. Employers know this and structure tasks accordingly — real engineering work, but at a scope that fits 20 hours a week.

Why German companies hire Werkstudents

- **Pipeline building.** Many full-time engineering offers in Germany begin as a Werkstudent contract that converts into a thesis project and then a graduate role.
- **Lower risk.** Companies can evaluate a candidate's real work over months, not interview rounds.
- **Cost-effective skilled work.** Students bring up-to-date tooling (Python, modern CAD, current PLC platforms) at part-time hours.
- **Knowledge transfer.** Werkstudents are often mentored by senior engineers, which builds long-term loyalty.

What a Werkstudent role is *not*

- It is not a generic mini-job (Minijob) — the legal classification and tax treatment are different.
- It is not an internship (Praktikum) — internships are usually full-time, time-boxed, and may be mandatory for your degree.
- It is not a freelance contract — you are an employee with a payslip and (limited) social insurance.
- It is not a guaranteed job offer — but it is the single best route into one.

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Many German employers use Werkstudent positions as a pipeline for internships, thesis projects and full-time hiring. Treat the role as a **multi-month interview**, not a side job.

02 Legal hours & study-permit rules

Before applying, every international student should understand the rules set out by *Make it in Germany*, the federal portal. The numbers below are the baseline — your individual residence permit may state stricter conditions, so always read it.

20 h MAX / WEEK DURING LECTURES	FULL DURING SEMESTER BREAKS	140 FULL DAYS PER YEAR	280 HALF DAYS PER YEAR
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The three rules students get wrong

- **The 20-hour cap is per calendar week, not averaged.** Working 30 hours one week and 10 the next is a violation, even if the average is 20.
- **Semester breaks are not unlimited time.** You can work more hours per week, but you still cannot exceed 140 full days (or 280 half days) *per year* in total.
- **Mandatory internships do not count.** If your degree requires a Pflichtpraktikum, those hours are usually outside the 140-day rule — but only when the internship is officially required by your study programme.

What this means in practice

Most engineering Werkstudent contracts in Germany are written for **16 to 20 hours per week** during the lecture period, with the option to scale to **35–40 hours** during semester breaks. This rhythm is expected and well understood by HR departments.



Always verify

Rules change. Confirm the current limits at [make-it-in-germany.com](https://www.make-it-in-germany.com) and check your own residence permit before you sign a contract.

03 The four engineering tracks employers hire most

Across hundreds of postings, four tracks dominate Werkstudent hiring in German engineering. Pick **one** as your primary target — generalists get filtered out faster than specialists.

1

Automation & PLC

Typical work

- PLC programming (Siemens TIA, Codesys)
- HMI development & visualization
- Documentation & functional specs
- Factory automation projects

Companies hiring

SIEMENS • FESTO • ABB • BOSCH

2

Embedded Systems

Typical work

- Firmware testing on real hardware
- Hardware validation & bring-up
- Embedded software support
- Sensor & bus diagnostics (CAN, SPI, I²C)

Companies hiring

BOSCH • Continental • Infineon

3

Mechanical Design

Typical work

- CAD modelling (CATIA, NX, SolidWorks)
- Engineering drawings & GD&T;
- Product development support
- Tolerance analysis & DFM checks

Companies hiring

BMW • Mercedes-Benz • Schaeffler

4

Data & Digital Engineering

Typical work

- Python scripting & automation
- Data analysis & cleaning
- Dashboard development (Power BI, Plotly)
- Process automation & ETL

Companies hiring

BOSCH • SIEMENS • SAP

04 What employers really look for

Recruiters at German engineering firms screen Werkstudent applications on four dimensions. Hit all four and you move from the pile to the shortlist.

Technical fit

Demonstrated skills in the relevant stack: PLC, Python, CAD, Embedded C/C++, data tooling, or mechanical fundamentals. Listing the tool is not enough — you must be able to explain a project you used it in.

Proof of work

Real artefacts: GitHub repos with commits, CAD drawings, lab reports, simulation outputs, dashboards, or a documented student project. Two clean proofs beat ten unfinished ones.

Communication

Clear written English is the baseline. Basic German (A2/B1) significantly widens the pool of available roles, especially at Mittelstand companies outside Munich and Berlin.

Reliability

Consistency matters more than brilliance. Employers want a student who shows up, communicates blockers early, and can balance the role with academic deadlines. Mention this explicitly in your application.



What employers value

Relevant projects • Technical fundamentals • Communication skills • Reliability & ownership

05 Search keywords & where to look

The single biggest reason students miss good roles is searching the wrong terms in the wrong places. The German market uses very specific keywords — use them verbatim.

High-signal search keywords

Search term (use verbatim)	Tools / context to mention in CV
Werkstudent Automation	PLC, Siemens, Festo, control engineering
Werkstudent PLC	TIA Portal, Codesys, ladder logic, HMI
Werkstudent Robotics	ROS, KUKA, ABB, motion planning, vision
Werkstudent Embedded Systems	C/C++, microcontrollers, firmware, RTOS
Werkstudent Mechanical Design	CATIA, NX, SolidWorks, GD&T, FEA
Werkstudent Data Engineering	Python, SQL, ETL, Power BI, dashboards

Where to search (in this order)

- **Company career pages first.** Bosch, Siemens, BMW, Continental, Infineon, Schaeffler, SAP, ABB, Festo — each lists Werkstudent roles directly. These pages have less competition than aggregators.
- **LinkedIn second.** Filter by location + 'Werkstudent' + your track. Set up daily alerts.
- **StepStone & Indeed.de third.** Useful for Mittelstand companies that don't post on LinkedIn.
- **University job boards.** Almost every Technische Universität has a Career Service portal with roles posted directly by employers.
- **Werkstudent-specific portals.** Sites like Berufsstart.de, Praktikum.info and Absolventa list student-only roles.

06 The application kit

Send exactly four artefacts. No bundle, no zip file, no marketing PDF. Each artefact has one job — keep it short and verifiable.

File	Purpose
CV (1 page, PDF)	Shows fit, tools, and project proof. Reverse-chronological. Branch + target role + tools in the headline. Skills section grouped by category. Two to three projects with measurable outcomes.
Cover letter (½ page)	Explains <i>why this role</i> and <i>why this company</i> . Avoid generic motivation. Name the team or product you applied to. State your availability and earliest start date.
Portfolio link	GitHub, personal site, Notion page, or a single PDF. Lets the recruiter verify your work in 60 seconds. Pin the most relevant project to the top.
Transcript / enrolment certificate	Provide when asked, especially for student roles. The <i>Immatrikulationsbescheinigung</i> proves you are enrolled and is often required to issue the contract.

CV priorities (in order)

- **Headline:** e.g. “B.Sc. Mechatronics • Werkstudent Automation • TIA Portal, Python, ROS”.
- **Education:** university, programme, expected graduation, GPA only if strong.
- **Projects (most important):** 2–3 entries with role, stack, and one measurable outcome.
- **Skills:** grouped — Programming / Hardware / Tools / Languages.
- **Experience:** any prior Werkstudent, internship, lab assistant, or student initiative.
- **Languages:** CEFR level, e.g. German B1, English C1.

What to say in a DM or first email

“Hi [Name], I am a [degree] student at [university] looking for Werkstudent roles in [track]. I have worked on [project] using [tools]. I am available for ~20 hours/week alongside my studies and can start [date]. My CV and portfolio are attached. Thank you for considering my application.”

07 Red flags that get you filtered out

Recruiters spend less than a minute on the first pass. These are the patterns that get a CV rejected before anyone reads it.

- ✗ **No proof of university enrolment.** The role is legally tied to student status — leaving this off is an instant filter.
- ✗ **Asking about salary before fit.** A first message that opens with hourly rate signals the wrong priorities. Discuss compensation after the screening call.
- ✗ **No CV or no project evidence.** A message that says “I am interested” without attachments is treated as spam.
- ✗ **Random applications without a target track.** A CV that lists every technology ever invented signals zero specialisation. Pick one track and own it.
- ✗ **Inconsistent German / English level.** If your CV claims C1 German but the email is in broken English, the recruiter assumes the higher claim is also false.
- ✗ **Generic cover letter.** If the same letter could be sent to ten companies, it should be sent to none.

✓ DO

- Pick one target track and stay on it for the full search.
- Attach a 1-page CV and a portfolio link in the first message.
- Mention your earliest start date and weekly availability.
- Use the exact role keyword (e.g. *Werkstudent Automation*).
- Mirror the company's tooling in your skills section.

✗ DON'T

- Send a generic 5-PDF bundle.
- Claim skills you cannot explain in an interview.
- Hide that you are a student — *Werkstudent requires it*.
- Write a 10-paragraph message with no role focus.
- Mass-apply with no customisation — recruiters can tell.

08 Your 30-day action plan

A focused month is enough to go from “I should apply” to a real interview pipeline. Treat each phase as a sprint with a clear deliverable.

Days 1–3 CHOOSE & POSITION	Pick one target track from Section 03. Rewrite your LinkedIn headline and CV title to match exactly: <i>Branch + Target role + Top 3 tools</i> . Delete anything off-track.
Days 4–7 BUILD THE KIT	Prepare a one-page CV. Update your LinkedIn profile photo, headline, and About section. Create or polish a portfolio link (GitHub README, Notion page, or single PDF).
Days 8–14 MAP THE MARKET	Collect 10 relevant job postings . List the keywords, tools, and responsibilities that repeat across them. These are the words that must appear in your CV.
Days 15–21 SHIP ONE PROOF	Finish one proof project end-to-end, or clean up an existing one. Add a README explaining what, why, how, and result. This is the single most leveraged week of the plan.
Days 22–30 APPLY & TRACK	Send 5–10 tailored applications per week . Track in a spreadsheet: company, role, date, status, follow-up date. Follow up after 7 days if no reply.

09 Frequently asked questions

Q. Do I need to speak German to get a Werkstudent role?

A. Not always. Large engineering employers (Bosch, Siemens, SAP, BMW R&D, Infineon) run English-language Werkstudent positions, especially in software, data, and embedded teams. Mittelstand companies and shop-floor automation roles usually require at least B1 German.

Q. How much does a Werkstudent earn?

A. Engineering Werkstudent pay typically ranges from **€14 to €20 per hour** in 2026, depending on company size, city, and track. Data, embedded, and automation roles trend higher than general mechanical.

Q. Can I do a Werkstudent role and an internship in the same year?

A. Yes, but watch the day count. The 140-full-day-per-year limit applies to all paid work combined. Mandatory internships (Pflichtpraktikum) required by your degree are usually excluded from the count — voluntary ones are not.

Q. How long should a Werkstudent contract be?

A. Most contracts run for 6–12 months and are renewable. Aim for at least 6 months: anything shorter rarely converts into a thesis or full-time offer.

Q. Can a Werkstudent role lead to a full-time job?

A. Yes — and this is the main reason to take one. The typical path is: Werkstudent → thesis project at the same company → graduate / full-time hire. Roughly half of engineering graduate hires in Germany follow this route.

Q. What if I'm in my first semester?

A. Most employers prefer students who have completed at least 1–2 semesters, but exceptions exist for software and data roles where prior project work is more important than coursework. Apply anyway — the worst case is a no.

10 Quick-reference cheatsheet

Save this page. It is the entire guide compressed into one screen.

The rules

- Max 20 hours/week during lectures
- Full hours during semester breaks
- 140 full / 280 half days per year
- Must stay enrolled the entire time

The four tracks

- Automation & PLC
- Embedded Systems
- Mechanical Design
- Data & Digital Engineering

The kit

- 1-page CV (PDF)
- ½-page cover letter
- Portfolio link
- Enrolment certificate

The search

- Company career pages first
- Then LinkedIn with daily alerts
- Use exact term: *Werkstudent* + *track*
- Mirror the posting's keywords

The 30-day plan

- D1–3: pick one track, rewrite headline
- D4–7: CV + LinkedIn + portfolio
- D8–14: collect 10 postings, mine keywords
- D15–21: ship one proof project
- D22–30: apply 5–10/week, track, follow up

The mindset

- Specialise, don't generalise
- Proof beats claims
- Reliability > brilliance
- Treat it as a multi-month interview

★ Bottom line

Send the student **one guide, one checklist, and one role-specific CV resource**. Do not overwhelm. Werkstudent hiring rewards focus, proof and reliability — in that order.

About this series

The **Engineering Hiring Intelligence — Werkstudent Series** is a set of practical resources for students moving from coursework to industry experience in Germany. We share hiring insight and career guidance only — we are not affiliated with the companies named in these documents and do not recruit on their behalf.

Companion resource

Pair this guide with the **Werkstudent Quick Checklist 2026** — a one-screen action sheet a student can finish in a single sitting and act on the same day.

Sources & references

- *Make it in Germany* — the federal portal for skilled workers and students ([make-it-in-germany.com](https://www.make-it-in-germany.com)).
- Career pages of Bosch, Siemens, BMW, Continental, Infineon, Schaeffler, SAP, ABB, Festo, Mercedes-Benz.
- University career service portals at major Technische Universitäten (TUM, RWTH Aachen, KIT, TU Berlin, TU Darmstadt).



Disclaimer

This document provides general hiring guidance. It is not legal or tax advice. Always confirm current Werkstudent rules with official German government sources and verify the conditions stated in your own residence permit and employment contract.